

CONTEMPORARY REFLECTIONS ON FRANK LANE'S 1915 ESSAY "FACULTY HELP IN INTERCOLLEGIATE CONTESTS"

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Abstract: In the first volume of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* Frank Lane addressed the issue of coaches producing arguments and evidence for debaters and competitive public speakers. There seems to have been a consensus in the academic ranks at the time that debate teams should have active coaches. However, early argumentation scholars disagreed over what limits, if any, should be imposed on the coach. At the beginning of the 20th century there was a concern that the lack of a definitive set of standards led to instructors intruding into debate in a way that could lead to unfair contests. In the early stages of the 21st century the increasing demands on policy debate coaches to produce evidence for students has profoundly negative implications on both the competitive balance in the modern community and on the ability of coaches to devote a full professional career to coaching policy debate. Frank Lane's essay raised the issue of evidence production for students and its effect on competitive balance in debate. A review of his work raises questions about the impact that coach produced evidence has on debate and the ways in which that practice undermines the pedagogical benefits of contest debating. After reviewing the trends in evidence production by coaches, this essay calls for the elimination of the evidence loophole in the American Forensics Association (AFA) code to return the research burden to forensics competitors.

In the first volume of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* University of Pittsburgh debate coach Frank H. Lane asked what is for many debate coaches a still unresolved question "How much help should an instructor of public speaking give to a student preparing for an intercollegiate contest" (p. 9)? In the second half of the essay Lane lamented the fact that some coaches con-

structed the speeches delivered by debaters and raised the question “But if the instructor makes the ultimate analysis, does he [sic] not dominate the debate” (p. 13)?

While there was a consensus in the academic ranks at the time that teams should not be without coaches, scholars disagreed over the meaning of what was the proper coaching template for the profession. At the beginning of the 20th century there was a concern that the lack of a definitive set of coaching standards for professionals led to unfair contests. The field of argumentation was in its infancy and there was no clear path for coaches to follow. In *Democracy as Discussion*, Keith (2007) described the establishment of The National Association of Academic Teachers of Public Speaking (NAATPS) in 1914 as it arose in response changes in deliberative discourse in American public life. Bartanen and Littlefield (2014) traced the changes in public argument beginning in the 1870s and used the phrase “Oratorical Era” to describe the evolving forms of speech contests that took place between the Civil War and World War I. By 1914, students were looking for off-campus outlets for debate contests and members the newly formed NAATPS were scholars who produced published research on the academic benefits of debate for both students and the greater university community.

The current issue of *Contemporary Argumentation and Debate* looks to our historical legacy in order to reflect upon practices in contemporary debate. This essay outlines the counterproductive role that the evidence producing coaching style plays in the contemporary policy debate community. The increasing demands on debate coaches to produce arguments for students can have profoundly negative implications on both the competitive balance in that community and on the ability of program directors to devote a full professional career

to coaching policy debate. This essay is divided into three sections. The first section reviews the Lane essay, drawing out elements of the controversy of his era that might help us understand some of today’s problems. The second section describes the ways in which equating coaching with evidence production had negatively impacted both the profession of coaching and the debate community. The brief conclusion of the paper offers a suggestion for making the profession of coaching a more academically inclusive one for individuals interested in pursuing the career.

A Reading of “Faculty Help in Intercollegiate Contests.”

I encourage any coach with an interest in the history of competitive debate to review Lane’s essay. He took, as a given, that the practice of debate coaching is framed by what he described as “custom.” While Lane did not define the term, my reading is that for Lane, custom was a repeated practice. Such practice is an established and unwritten law or norm.

There was widespread disagreement in 1915 over the role that coaches should play in the construction of strategies and arguments. The Lane essay drew the distinction between the British approach, which eschews professional coaching, and the American system that allows for active coaching including the construction and improvement of arguments. The professional commitment to help in the production of researched arguments was a distinct element of the American debate culture. The addition of coaches who produced arguments with and for students led, in some cases, to additional attention to the invention phase of speech construction in American debating teams.

The differences in the Oxford system and the American debate system generate very different forms of

speechmaking and this difference is still apparent in the 21st century. For example, the University of Georgia policy debate program and Oxford University have a running series of debates that take place every three years. In each of the iterations of the series the teams take distinct, but very predictable, approaches to a resolution. After each set of debates, I am left with the impression that the American approach is one that is one that best prepares students to fully research and interrogate the issues and problems that will surface in their lifetimes. Alternately, the British approach prepares students to better connect with an informed public audience with an interest in a controversy and privileges refutation skills rather than evidence based argument construction.

Coaches at the beginning of the 20th century confronted the same duality that confronts the debate community today. One objective was to win contest debates. A second objective was to educate the student. When these objectives were in apparently in conflict, the educational objective was often trumped by the competitive desires. “When the ideal of victory is uppermost, the instructor shows the student how to do a particular thing instead of revealing the principle and letting him [sic] work out its applications. This tends to destroy the educational ideal” (Lane, 1915, p, 14). For Lane, the conflicting ideals and a lack standards to clearly define the “province of the instructor” led, in some cases, to contests in which students were denied the opportunity of learning by doing.

There have been a number of essays written on the characteristics a debate coach should aspire to since the inaugural issue of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*. By and large, scholars writing about the role that coaches play in squad development do not comment on an evidence production role some coaches feel com-

pelled to play for their squads. Rosenthal (1997) concluded that coaches should travel students, teach them the value of competition, and work with administrators to highlight the skills developed by debate. Attaway (1977) called on prospective coaches to reflect upon their attitudes towards forensic pedagogy. And while he called for reflection on everything remotely related to coaches, his essay did not comment on the appetite of some coaches to research for their debaters. McBath (1975) reported on the National Developmental Conference held at Sedalia Colorado and outlined the future directions for forensics educators. While summarizing the qualifications necessary to be a coach, developing the skills of an accomplished evidence producer is not found in the recommendations suggested by the Sedalia Conference. In the essay “Is Directing of Forensics a Profession?” Quimby (1963) discussed the need to have specialized training but did not speculate upon the evidence production function. And while Windes (1960) lamented the costs of having an “unprepared” or “poorly motivated” coach on a forensics program, there was no discussion of research techniques that might improve coaching performance. Dobkin’s (1958) thoughtful essay detailed the roles that a forensic educator plays in citizenship formation. While he did not directly address evidence production, he seemed to implicitly assail the rationale behind coaches producing evidence to improve the chance of victory by affirming that “the tournament is more than a contest, that it is a true educational experience in rhetorical training (205).” Finally, while Campbell (1934) reflected on what defines a successful season and concluded that winning a fair share of contests is a marker of success, again there is no suggestion made that a coach craft and draft winning arguments for the contestants.

The scholarly literature on forensics educators and their obligations tends to sidestep the evidence production issue raised by Lane. Given that coaches have been constructing arguments for debaters for one hundred years, this is an interesting oversight. Perhaps this omission is due, in part, to the difficulty associated with explaining this practice to faculty in other academic communities. In traditional undergraduate settings, students research to facilitate the scholarship of a faculty member. Alternately, a faculty member reviews and edits work for students interested in producing their own scholarly undergraduate research programs. In the vast majority of academic settings, professionals do not help their students by generating their research product.

Lane described the range of “help” that coaches provided students in both public speaking contests and debates dating back to the turn of the 20th century. He shared a story of a coach who took a job and was deemed unsuccessful when compared to his predecessor. The coach, who did not produce arguments for students, learned that his predecessor had written most of the “main speeches” and rebuttals for the students. Lane reviewed the literature of the day and quoted Professor Lyman writing in the *Public Speaking Review* “The debate . . . displays the work of the coaches and not of the debaters themselves” (p.13). For many professionals of that era, when a coach elected to dominate the practice of debate, it destroyed the assumption that the debate is between students. While the problem has always been easy to diagnose, there was little agreement on the solution. Lane explained, “Professor Robinson says that there is a consensus of opinion that a team ought not to be without a coach, and that there is an educative value in intense preparation under proper direction. But how are we to interpret ‘proper direction’ (1915, p.13)?

Lane’s position, that finding a “proper direction” that is a compromise between a ban on argument production and a coach dominating the construction process, would probably have been doomed to failure. Then, like today, coaches were people who were invested in the competitive success of their students. Lane noted,

Professor O’Neill makes an interesting comment on the struggle between these two ideals (education and competition). The desire to win becomes so strong that it affects not only the team but the coach also. The coach is always a human being, and when he is constantly working with a team whose single thought is how to win this debate, it is almost impossible for him to adhere strictly to the pedagogical purpose of the contest. But even if at the start the coach is sufficiently conscientious of his [sic] ideals as a teacher, he is hardly allowed to remain so. The student body, the local press, and the school board demand victory. The instructor sees that it is victory or his [sic] job, and he needs the job. (Lane, 1915, p.14)

In the conclusion of the essay, Lane suggested two well-recognized paths generally taken to achieving the goal of making a debate a contest between matched contestants. The first path is to preclude students from receiving aid in the construction and delivery of a speech. The second is that the instructor could act, without limit, to prepare the students for debates. He suggested a third path that would move debate to a model in which students would attend debates with a limited understanding of the topic area and would be expected to deliver extemporaneous speeches on topics drawn just before the debate. While the third path is an intriguing one, I will limit the discussion here to the first two options outlined by Lane. This self-imposed

limitation is tied to my desire to focus on the issues that result from debating a policy question for an entire season.

The Custom of Evidence Production Based Coaching in Modern Policy Debate

The custom of coaches helping students produce and construct arguments is one that predates my introduction to intercollegiate policy debate. When I arrived at the University of Massachusetts in the mid 1970s, I was greeted with a set of sophisticated air pollution files that were written in part by Thomas J. Hynes, the current President of Clayton State University in Georgia, who was a recently minted Ph.D. at the time. By the mid-1970s, there were a number of successful evidence producing coaches across the country.

While there have always been coaches who research for students, the number seems to have grown substantially in the last twenty years. In the decades of the 1960s, 1970s, and 1980s, the debate coach at most universities was a tenure-track faculty member who could not devote much time to researching for debaters. As has been the case across all disciplines, there has been a substantial reduction in tenure track positions available to debate coaches. The tenure track coach usually has teaching and personal research obligations to attend to in their professional life.

A recent survey of coaching positions found that the nature of the position now varies widely from institution to institution (Rowland, 2010). The transition away from tenure track faculty assigned to work with debate has resulted in programs managed by coaches without terminal degrees or teaching obligations. These coaches, untethered from traditional faculty obligations are able to devote more time into all of the elements of coaches. They can listen to additional practice speeches,

manage additional strategy sessions, and produce more evidence for the squad. The pattern of coaches producing files for debaters has been an accepted, and largely uncontested, practice in the policy debate world for upwards of ten generations of competitors. The practice has been exacerbated by the changing academic status of the debate coach at a university.

While some current programs are organized in a way that require debaters to exclusively produce their own arguments, it would be fair to say that the dominant custom in the field is that coaches produce files. The community often celebrates these motivated and committed individuals as “successful” coaches. Until very recently, the appetite for more evidence created a cottage industry the weekly evidence update that was available for download. This service has been supplanted by the move to Open Source evidence. Open Source is a voluntary project in which teams upload their speeches and evidence for later use by other teams. Each of these innovations made evidence more accessible to students while simultaneously increased the premium placed on real-time file production by coaches. The custom of coach-generated research has not been called into question by the introduction of alternate research options born of advances in technology. Debate follows the pattern found in other industries, workers today find themselves logging more than 150 additional hours a year on the job when compared to the U.S. worker of just a generation ago (Schor, 1993).

I would be remiss if I did not acknowledge the impact that continuous evidence production has on students. In some programs, debaters work to match the coaches in their research production. Students in these squads find themselves sacrificing some college experiences to focus on argument production. In other programs, coach generated research has afforded

students the chance to participate in a number of clubs and extracurricular activities that previous generations of debaters were forced to pass on to keep pace with their competitors on the debate circuit. The impact of a coach's evidence production on the student experience is mixed based on the culture of a particular squad.

The current world of debate is radically different than the one that Lane found himself in when he drafted his *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* essay. When Lane forwarded the option of unfettered coaching support, he could not have imagined the current coaching staff. Contemporary policy debate programs may have upwards of five coaches who produce files for debaters. In many cases, these coaches have never been forced to juggle the demands of coaching and teaching. And, there are some programs where the staff does not have an affiliation with a department or another campus unit. There are intercollegiate debate programs that operate without reflecting on their commitment to, or being accountable to, the institutional or educational missions of their college.

The specialization and resource asymmetries found in the debate community mirrors the changes found in our larger society. The debate community has always struggled with the objective of equalizing the experience for students from different university environments. There have always been coaches who worked harder than their colleagues. There have always been coaches who are better at communicating with and inspiring their debaters to produce research. And, there have always been coaches who are brighter than their peers. Some of these asymmetries are irresolvable.

Resource disparities between programs functionally obliterate the ability to sustain a system in which the competitive environment, between matched con-

testants, is fair and balanced. Accordingly, the current system of unregulated coaching support and evidence production is not in the best interest of the community. Despite moving stories of how a few motivated individuals have been able to overcome resource differences and excel, those tales are the exception rather than the rule. Additionally, the stories of the extraordinary and motivated student may not be helpful in determining what organizing principles best approximate a contest between matched contestants in the community. The debate community may be better served by finding organizing principles that facilitate the participation of students that are devoted to the activity but may be unwilling to sacrifice all elements of the undergraduate experience to compete at the highest level.

The policy debate circuit has evolved into one that has its own 1% problem. Over the last few decades we have witnessed a number of strategic innovations formulated by programs that were on the short end of the resource equation that have propelled them to competitive success. When one looks back thirty years one can identify the introduction of generics, counterplans, topical counterplans, and kritiks. Smaller programs, to offset the advantages of resource rich programs, have often leveraged such innovations. Often the debate community confronts the emerging controversies associated with "deviant tactics" without looking at the ways in which the competitive landscape pushes people to experiment and reject the orthodoxy of the day.

As a side note, the current controversy over race and class in debate may be different than previous efforts that upset the competitive hierarchy. For example, programs that defined themselves as classical policy squads were, over a period of time, able to absorb and deploy Kritik arguments. Today, programs that may have struggled in the classical policy debate environ-

ment have flourished in the world of race and performance based debate. Many bright students who have not benefitted from extensive high school training have embraced the new model and experienced remarkable competitive success. There are some traditional powers that have moved in this direction and have diversified their undergraduate population. In other cases admissions offices at public institutions have hamstrung the diversification efforts of the debate program. We now have programs that cannot compete financially and others who face a new set of admissions restricts that do not effectively diversify the student population. If the Supreme Court continues to erode affirmative action admissions at public institutions, the debate world will find itself with private institutions with an increasingly diverse student population and some public institutions that have historically diverse populations competing along with public institutions that admit a largely Caucasian student body. The politics of gender, race and sexual identity may become increasingly complicated in the years to come. Perhaps the introduction of identity and race serve as a corrective for some institutions that do not have the resources to hire one or more card cutting coaches. And, as the resource disparities grow, more students and teams may elect to move to deploying performance and identity based argument strategies in debates.

The coaching disparities have made it increasingly difficult for smaller programs to compete in the evidence based policy debate that many believe serves both the short and long term interests of the students. This condition happened to coincide with the introduction of performance studies and identity based research in a number of academic disciplines. In the classroom and in journal essays students find themselves exposed to a diverse set of perspectives that are in many cases

transferrable to the competitive debate environment. The squad comprised of 4-6 students with one coach, who has other university obligations, should not be expected to regularly compete with program staffed by a faculty member, a full time coach with limited or no teaching obligations and a group of GTAs. Teams that find they lacking robust institutional support generate many of the theoretical innovations in debate. And, today these innovations include the introduction of performance and identity politics into policy debate.

The current model of unrestricted coaching support may be unsustainable for at least two categories of debate coaches, the faculty member and the graduate teaching assistant. In "Development and Advancement in the Coaching Profession: A Report on Professional Debate Coaching Positions and Benchmarks for the Profession," Hingstman and Hahn (2010) described changes in the academy that have impacted the working conditions for both faculty coaches and GTAs assigned to work with debate at research institutions. Many faculty members find themselves with additional on-campus professional demands that compete with their ability to work with debaters. The GTAs find themselves with the expectation of producing published essays to be competitive for permanent employment in the changing job market. Programs constructed with coaching staffs that have commitments to establish their own personal research profiles are at a decided advantage in today's policy debate community.

Beyond the changing profile of the profession, technological changes call into question the rationale found in the American Forensics Association (AFA) code that justifies the practice of coaches producing evidence for debaters. Article II, 2 A & B of the code indicate that coaches are not to get charged with the primary responsibility for research. Coaches can research for students

to improve their research techniques, provide examples of research, to frame the squad's research agenda, and to provide the coach with a topic specific knowledge base (American Forensics Association, 2009).

It is important to note that the compromise found in the AFA code was drafted before the advent of the Internet. As Hingstman and Hahn pointed out:

Digital resources are making research and networking increasingly accessible . . . new initiatives in the field of open source debate make evidence sharing, such as the Open Caselist, a powerful tool for new programs to engage and compete against established teams. It is no coincidence that the winners of the NDT tend to be the schools with the largest coaching staffs, but the increased distribution of free sharing of evidence and resources have made smaller debate programs increasingly capable of competing against larger institutions. (2010, p. 133)

As for those who embrace the custom of producing evidence, technology has negatively impacted their work environment. Into the early 1990s, tournaments had social gatherings in the evening when a coach could get to know others in the profession. In that era, the library would close and evidence production was not a regular expectation of the job until the morning papers arrived at the tournament hotel around 6:00 AM. Today, coaches find themselves producing files late into the evening. For many, this is a physically demanding practice and an unsustainable professional tract. Ours is a profession, as currently constituted, that pushes many to the sidelines before they reach age 40. The regular late night research obligation at tournaments reflects the work pattern of the apprentice or new associate not the seasoned professional.

Conclusion

In any intellectual community, members often easily dismiss questioning an accepted custom. I am cognizant that it is in the interest of individual programs that students find relief from the research burden associated with policy debate. And, there is the obvious concern that individuals would cheat and produce evidence in a world in which coaches could not do so. But, the current costs imposed on the profession call for careful reflection on the accepted custom of coaches and paid staff producing arguments for competitors.

My contention is that the move to the digital era has rendered irrelevant the need for an exception to the AFA code. It was written at a time that coaches were often tied to working in a local library with their debaters to produce evidence. In that era, the access to both evidence and information from opposing schools was limited. In the digital age a group, like the AFA or the Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA) could contract with a skilled researcher to produce a starter packet for programs when the topic is announced in August. I have observed how this process works at the high school level. Each year, for example, the Georgia High School Association produces a series of starter packets for young debaters. This product benefits both young debaters and new coaches who have been assigned to coach debate by their school administration. Throughout the year coaches could regularly cull the caselists to help students identify new strategies to improve their competitive chances at tournaments. A close reading of the case list would also serve to provide coaches with a solid working knowledge of the topic, vacating yet another loophole found in the AFA code.

At this point, I have elected to stake out the no assistance option outlined by Lane. Moving to an envi-

ronment in which coaches continue to read about the topic and suggest lines of research for students without producing files would drastically impact the debate community. Coaches would still invest hundreds of hours preparing teams to debate, but their work product would look much different. In such an environment coaches would identify research areas, carefully monitor speech documents that have been uploaded to a caselist, and listen to practice debates and speeches.

I have heard from members of our program that in the current environment we may not be able to field competitive teams absent evidence production by staff members. This was not the case even just ten years ago. Given that the accepted custom has evolved into an unsustainable educational and work environment for many, reflecting on the issues raised by Frank Lane may be helpful for policy debate in the 21st century in the hopes of developing a more inviting and inclusive setting for both students and coaches.

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